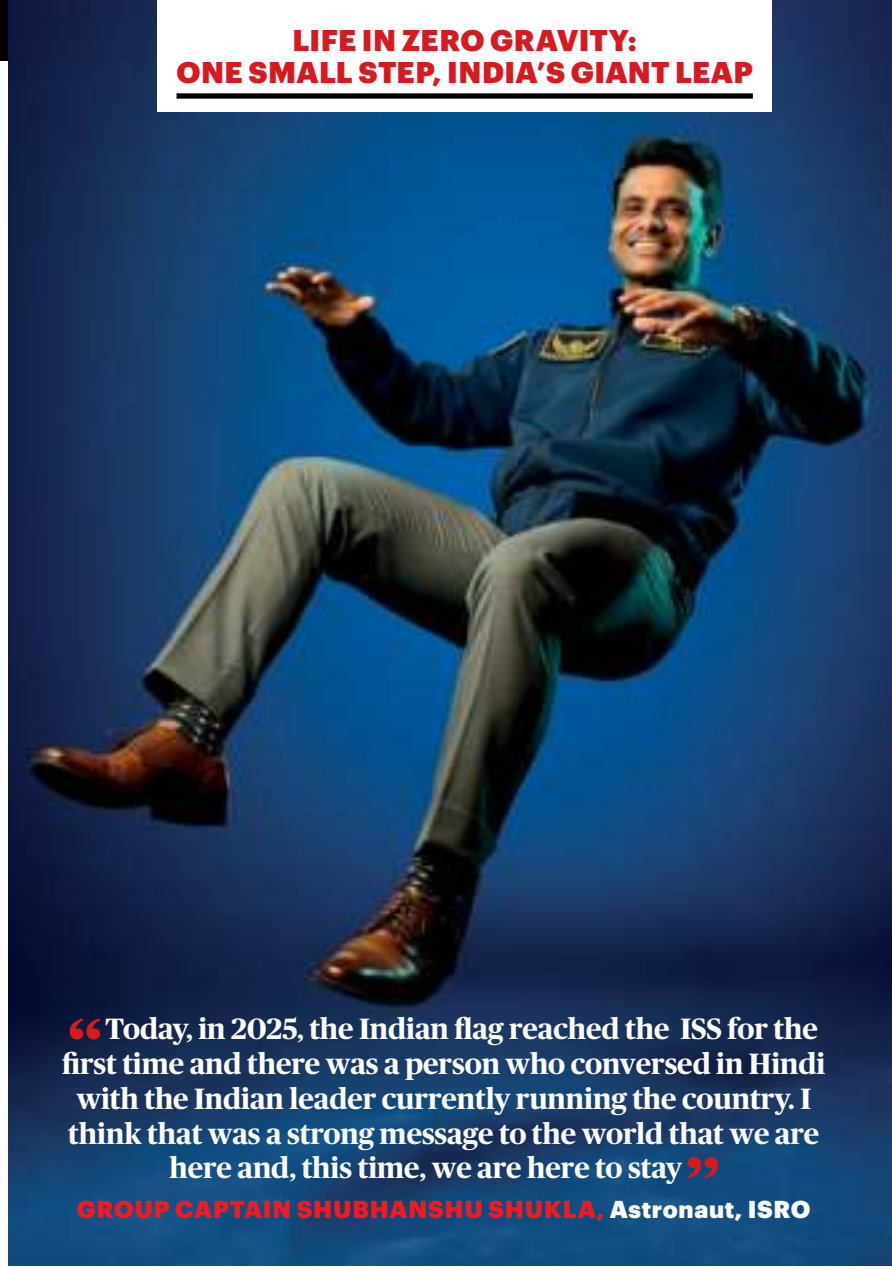
INDIA TODAY CONCLAVE MUMBAI

LIFE IN ZERO GRAVITY: ONE SMALL STEP, INDIA'S GIANT LEAP



"Today, in 2025, the Indian flag reached the ISS for the first time and there was a person who conversed in Hindi with the Indian leader currently running the country. I think that was a strong message to the world that we are here and, this time, we are here to stay"

GROUP CAPTAIN SHUBHANSHU SHUKLA, Astronaut, ISRO

Photographs by **BANDEEP SINGH**

From a chief minister defending coalition politics to an astronaut recalling India's leap into space, the India Today Conclave – Mumbai (September 25-26) offered a vivid tableau of ideas for a changing world. The two-day conclave opened with the session 'Maharashtra's Master Strategist: What Drives Fadnavis 3.0?', where Chief Minister Devendra Fadnavis said, "The BJP acts as that strong pole with 137 seats, ensuring no major issues," defending the coalition government's stability while outlining a positive fiscal outlook despite welfare spending.

Later, in a session, Yuva Sena president Aaditya Thackeray criticised the government for its language policy. Turning to the BMC, where elections are due this year, he said the civic body's finances remained robust during the undivided Shiv Sena's rule, but the metro's problems are many. State IT and cultural affairs minister Ashish Shelar stressed the urgency of preparing Mumbai for frequent flooding due to climate change.

Political activist Yogendra Yadav, lawyer Ashwini Upadhyay and former chief election commissioner Om Prakash Rawat debated the fraught special intensive revision of electoral rolls and its implications for assembly polls. On the RSS's centenary, author Tushar Gandhi warned that "Godse's voice finds more resonance and empathy than Gandhi's," while *Organiser* editor Prafulla Ketkar reminded the audience that M.S. Golwalkar, the second RSS chief, was the first to denounce Gandhi's assassin.

The defence and diplomacy sessions shifted the focus outward. Lt Gen. Dhiraj Seth, Air Marshal Surat Singh and Vice Admiral Krishna Swaminathan detailed the precision and synergy behind Operation Sindoor, while former diplomats Meera Shankar, Jawed Ashraf and Ajay Bisaria cautioned against relying too heavily on a single trade partner.

Astronaut Group Captain Shubhanshu Shukla described India's space exploration as a "golden period", while AI experts Srikant Velamakanni, R. Chandrasekhar and Deep Mukherjee stressed the need to close India's technology gaps. Former Chief Justice of India D.Y. Chandrachud called for speedier case disposal and greater transparency in judicial appointments.

The business session featured entrepreneur Ananya Birla on microfinance and legacy, NSE CEO Ashish Chauhan on India's global positioning and economists Sajjid Chinoy, Samiran Chakraborty and Tanvee Gupta Jain on the risks of US tariffs. Healthcare and culture sessions rounded off the spectrum—from Dr P. Murali Doraiswamy on neurological threats to candid reflections on recognition and purpose by actor Rani Mukerji, producer Ekta Kapoor and actor Bhumi Satish Pednekkar. ■

-by M.G. Arun

VOTER ROLL REVISION:



"Of 7.24 crore people of Bihar, 987 applications have been filed on the ground of someone being a foreigner... just 215 are Muslims"

YOGENDRA YADAV
Political Activist; Founder, Swaraj India